



# Artificial Intelligence and the Bright Internet: Transforming the Internet for a Better Future

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## 1 Introduction

Artificial intelligence (AI) is the subject of growing interest and debate worldwide, based on both the benefits and the adverse impact it may have and is already having on individuals, societies, and polity. Many studies have highlighted how AI is having both positive and negative effects in organizations. For example, AI is creating efficiencies through automation and enhancing productivity in areas such as operations, financial management, marketing, and human resource management. It is also bringing about greater reliability in project outcomes and is helping with innovation and standardization of processes. AI is now pervading online ecosystems such as social media, digital platforms, and sharing economy platforms, where it is creating more engaging user experiences through content and user recommendations. However, AI also has detrimental effects, such as contributing to technostress among users and employees

as it creates new uncertainties about evolving job roles and employment security.

Of growing interest is the impact of Generative AI (GAI) products such as ChatGPT and Dall-E (Susarla et al., 2023). GAI platforms interact with users, generating texts and images from an expansive web of information. GAI tools are driven by large language models (LLMs) and typically are used in applications such as chatbots (Kushwaha & Kar, 2024). Beyond GAI in chatbots, AI is gradually percolating into different spheres of work in business. However, there is evidence that factors impacting user experiences and adoption of AI tend to vary among stakeholders as roles for AI users continue to evolve (Kar & Kushwaha, 2023; Merhi, 2021). For example, a new area of work deliverables has emerged in recent job descriptions: prompt engineering, which requires proficiency in using AI to obtain suitable programming code or business documentation. This development has been particularly striking in the information technology (IT) and IT-enabled services industries, which are gradually moving from a low-code to a no-code environment. Goldman Sachs predicts that AI automation will eliminate 300 million jobs worldwide (Kelley, 2023), and GAI is expected to expedite these changes.

Given how easily content can be generated using GAI, concerns are arising about the spread of GAI-produced misinformation and disinformation using social media. This may create societal challenges surrounding belief and trust in various platforms and institutions. Polarization of belief systems is likely to occur in virtual communities. Further echo-chamber effects may have a larger impact on the way polarization increases within virtual communities due to misuse of GAI-produced content. This could potentially have significant adverse impacts on various internet ecosystems and their stakeholders.

Recent editorial deliberations (Dwivedi et al., 2023) have highlighted how GAI can enhance productivity and change employment opportunities, particularly in terms of augmenting or complementing human skills. Some believe that

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GAI may negatively impact the cognitive skills and critical thinking abilities of human users. However, others believe that industry and academia need to embrace GAI and create environments that foster higher-level cognitive skills and innovation (Susarla et al., 2023). Many concerns about data privacy, fairness, accountability, and trust have been highlighted in recent editorials on the adverse impacts of AI (Mikalef et al., 2022; Sivarajah et al., 2023). It is widely argued that while AI may enable digital transformation, we must also work to ensure sustainable societies in the future (Pappas et al., 2023).

Through this special issue, we aim to spark critical reflection, cross-disciplinary dialogue, and practical innovation. We invited scholars, policymakers, and practitioners to contribute to and extend the Bright Internet and Bright AI paradigm—bridging the gap between what is technically possible, what is ethically necessary, and what is globally sustainable. This special issue brought together leading researchers and practitioners to explore how we can reimagine and re-engineer the foundations of cyberspace and AI to serve the public good.

## 2 The Bright Internet and Bright AI Framework

We are living through a defining moment in the digital age. As global internet connectivity expands and AI becomes increasingly powerful and pervasive, societies are confronted with a dual reality. While these technologies offer transformative benefits—enhancing productivity, decision-making, and quality of life—they also introduce growing risks, from cyberattacks and disinformation to privacy intrusions and ethical failures in automated systems. The adoption of GAI, in particular, has the potential to amplify adverse impacts on individuals, firms, and societies if appropriate frameworks are not developed and adopted adequately.

In response to the complex challenges that may emerge from the adoption and appropriation of AI, the concept of the Bright Internet (Lee, 2015; Lee et al., 2018), and its natural evolution into Bright AI, presents a timely and transformative vision for building a secure, ethical, and human-centered digital future.

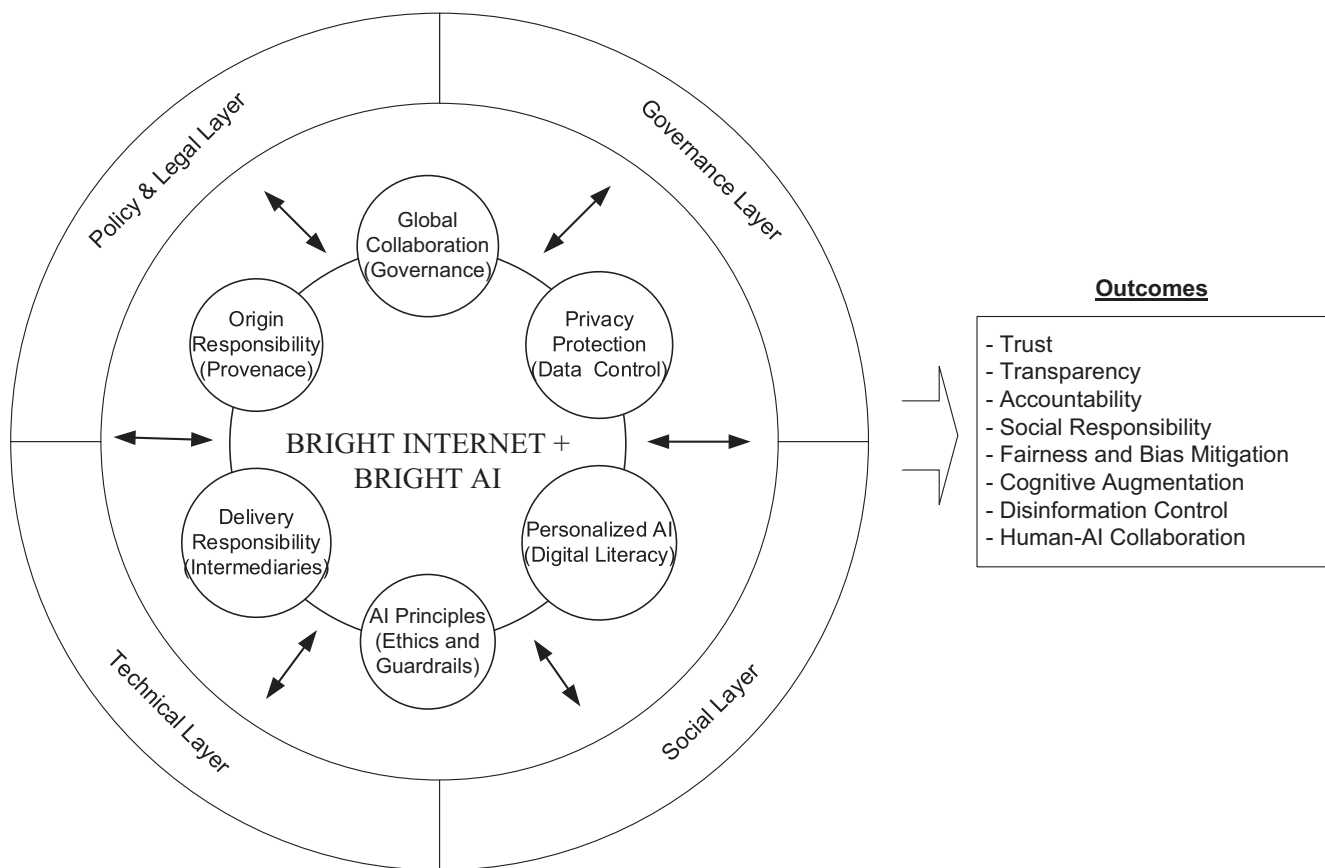
Driving this emerging vision, we propose a Bright Internet and Bright AI framework—an integrative model that combines secure technologies, responsible AI ethics, and coordinated global governance to transform the internet landscape. It is shown in Fig. 1.

The framework is anchored by six foundational pillars, each addressing a key dimension of responsibility and ethical alignment:

- **Origin Responsibility:** Ensures that digital content and AI-generated outputs are traceable to accountable sources, helping to combat anonymous threats and disinformation. Embedded within this pillar is the concept of *source fairness*, which calls for the inclusive and equitable creation of digital and AI content. This highlights the need to integrate diverse cultural, linguistic, and ideological perspectives into content-generation processes and training data. This pillar aims to reduce bias, promote representational justice, and foster more socially responsive AI systems by propagating Bright Origins.
- **Delivery Responsibility:** Focuses on the role of intermediaries, such as internet platforms, service providers, and AI-driven distribution systems. This principle emphasizes the need for secure, ethical, and balanced content dissemination. Platform fairness is central here: digital platforms must resist over-optimizing for engagement metrics at the expense of content balance and integrity. Instead, they should be designed to support pluralism, reduce algorithmic amplification of extremism, and ensure that users are exposed to a range of credible viewpoints.
- **Personalized AI:** Reframes the user-facing pillar around the design of the framework, highlighting the importance of user awareness, digital literacy, and critical engagement with content, especially when interacting with AI-generated information. It includes destination fairness, which addresses the risks of echo chambers, filter bubbles, and opinion polarization. Platforms and content delivery systems should strive to ensure that diverse perspectives reach end users, encouraging deliberative exposure and supporting cognitive diversity in digital discourse.
- **Privacy Protection:** Advances privacy-by-design and data sovereignty. This principle ensures that individuals retain control over their data and that AI systems operate transparently, with user consent and minimal intrusion.
- **Global Collaboration:** Emphasizes the necessity of international cooperation among governments, industry, and civil society to harmonize AI and internet governance in an increasingly borderless digital world.
- **AI Principles:** Stresses the importance of explainable, fair, and accountable AI. This pillar advocates clear ethical boundaries to prevent misuse, bias, and harm, ensuring that AI remains aligned with human values.

These principles operate within four strategic implementation layers that provide structure and context:

- **Technical Layer:** Involves the design of infrastructure, cybersecurity protocols, and responsible AI architectures that embed security and ethics from the ground up.



**Fig. 1** Bright Internet and Bright AI Framework

- **Social Layer:** Focuses on public education, digital and AI literacy, and cultivation of cultural norms that support ethical technology use.
- **Governance Layer:** Covers platform oversight, institutional transparency, and systems of algorithmic accountability to enforce ethical standards.
- **Policy and Legal Layer:** Encompasses legislation, treaties, and regulatory alignment that provide enforceable frameworks for digital and AI accountability on a global scale.

By aligning principles and practices across these layers, the Bright Internet and Bright AI framework aims to deliver a range of meaningful societal outcomes, including enhanced trust in digital systems and AI, greater transparency and explainability in algorithmic decision-making, strengthened accountability among digital actors, promotion of social responsibility in technology design and use, fairness and bias mitigation in AI systems, cognitive augmentation that empowers users, effective disinformation control, and constructive human–AI collaboration.

This framework is not merely aspirational. It is an actionable and adaptable roadmap. It envisions a future in which innovation is pursued in tandem with ethical responsibility,

and where trust becomes a cornerstone rather than a casualty of digital progress. As AI and the internet increasingly shape our societies, they can no longer be treated as neutral tools. They are powerful forces that must be guided with care, foresight, and collective responsibility.

### 3 The Special Issue

The goal of this special issue was to bring together a collection of innovative research, supported by solid theory building and rigorous empirical analysis, on the use of AI for enhancing the benefits of the Bright Internet. The articles selected for this special issue represent a wide variety of research on different Bright AI themes that aim to be impactful and even transformative for individuals, organizations, and society. The journey towards the special issue started with the Bright Internet Global Symposium in December 2023 and culminated in the selection of six papers that went through multiple rounds of blind reviews by at least two reviewers each to reach the stage of acceptance and publication. We summarize the accomplishments and the contributions of these six selected articles in the following paragraphs.

French & Shim ((French, and Shim, 2025)) deliberate between AI and augmented intelligence (IA) for enhancing rather than replacing human capabilities. Grounded in sociotechnical systems (STS) theory and the Dunning–Kruger effect, they distinguish IA’s assistive role in decision-making and cognitive amplification. Findings from three case studies demonstrate IA’s potential to create jobs, reduce costs, and improve outcomes and help to create a framework that extends STS to describe symbiotic human–AI relationships.

Khan et al. (2025) investigate the impact of cybersecurity incidents on social responsibility risks and stock price drops by analyzing incident descriptions from the Privacy Rights Clearinghouse database. Using sentiment analysis, topic modeling, and machine learning models, they find that outward-oriented incidents significantly affect social responsibility risk indices and stock prices. The study proposes a short-term social responsibility risk index for cybersecurity, acknowledging the mismatch between annual risk indices and short-term stock price impacts.

Kurumathur et al. (2025) investigate polarization in social media discourse following two 2020 incidents of vigilantism involving an aggressor and a victim. They analyze 287,545 tweets using sentiment analysis and text summarization to compare public opinion, themes, and emotional responses in aggressor- versus victim-oriented discussions. They establish that aggressor-oriented discourse is significantly more polarized, with a larger proportion of pro-vigilante sentiment. They suggest that media-related discussions are more polarizing in aggressor discourses, highlighting the need for platform interventions to reduce polarization.

Moin et al. (2025) address the evolving employee–employer relationship amid rising automation and AI integration. Using social exchange theory, they examine how psychological contract fulfillment affects organizational commitment, with trust as a mediator and AI acceptance as a moderator. The problem centers on declining job security and its effect on worker commitment. They establish that psychological contract fulfillment boosts trust and commitment, but AI adoption weakens these effects, likely due to job uncertainty. They contribute to literature on trust, psychological contracts, and AI’s disruptive impact on workforce dynamics in digitally transforming organizations.

Shahi et al. (2025) investigate how Twitter discourse during the 2019 European parliament election in Germany reflects political agenda formation and voting tendencies. Grounded in agenda-setting theory, the study identifies how different actors such as experts and political competitors influence public discussion. By analyzing annotated tweets using machine learning models, they establish that speech type and the user’s political role are strong predictors of

voting tendencies. The results advance election forecasting and agenda-setting research through enriched social media data.

Vasist & Krishnan (2025) address how a nation’s AI capacity influences progress toward the United Nations (UN) Sustainable Development Goals. Framed by the technology enactment framework, the problem lies in fragmented understanding of how AI’s multifaceted dimensions, such as infrastructure, regulation, talent, and commercial activity, collectively impact sustainability. Using data from 59 countries, the study applies fuzzy-set qualitative comparative analysis to uncover six necessary conditions and three key configurations for advancement of these goals. They argue that robust access infrastructure and strong regulatory environments are more critical than commercial ventures or even AI talent.

Table 1 lists some important details of the papers that were selected for this special issue.

## 4 Future Research Directions

As the Bright Internet and Bright AI framework envisions a secure, ethical, and human-centered digital future, future research can empirically operationalize its foundational pillars. This includes developing assessment tools to measure the real-world effectiveness of concepts such as origin responsibility, platform fairness, and destination fairness in reducing bias, enhancing content traceability, and mitigating polarization. Empirical studies, both qualitative and quantitative, can explore how these principles influence user trust, content credibility, and engagement on AI-driven platforms.

A second area for future research involves understanding the human and organizational implications of GAI. As GAI tools reshape cognitive labor and enable novel roles such as prompt engineering, researchers should examine how these technologies affect critical thinking, decision-making, and learning outcomes. Longitudinal studies could investigate the cognitive trade-offs associated with frequent GAI use, especially among younger users and knowledge workers. At the organizational level, further inquiry into human–AI collaboration models—particularly those based on augmented intelligence can help identify how firms can balance automation with human judgment to foster trust, productivity, and innovation.

Finally, researchers should investigate the broader societal and policy dimensions of the Bright Internet and Bright AI framework. This includes examining how misinformation and disinformation propagate differently through GAI-generated content due to the ability to fabricate realistic yet false content (such as deepfakes) and evaluating the efficacy of algorithmic interventions in

**Table 1** Summary of papers selected for the special issue

| Authors                  | Broad area of research      | Key focus                                                                                                                               | Methodology                                                                                                                                                          | Findings                                                                                                                                                                                                    | Implications                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|--------------------------|-----------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| French & Shim (2025)     | Bright AI for organizations | Studied augmented intelligence, which focuses on enhancing human capabilities rather than replacing them.                               | Literature review and analysis of three case studies to differentiate augmented intelligence from AI and explore its role in job creation and cognitive enhancement. | Augmented intelligence can create new jobs, improve efficiency and enhance human decision-making, whereas AI brings in automation to replace jobs.                                                          | Organizations should adopt an augmented intelligence framework to bring symbiotic human-machine collaboration to drive productivity and innovation.                                                          |
| Khan et al. (2025)       | Bright AI for organizations | Investigated how cybersecurity incidents impacted social security risks and stock prices.                                               | Sentiment analysis, topic modeling and machine learning were used on 11,705 cybersecurity incidents.                                                                 | Outward-facing cybersecurity incidents increased social responsibility risks and led to short-time decreases in stock prices.                                                                               | Outward-facing risks should be prevented to reduce reputational damage and financial loss.                                                                                                                   |
| Kurumathur et al. (2025) | Bright AI for individuals   | Examined polarization in social media discourse between aggressor-oriented and victim-oriented vigilantism discussions.                 | Content analysis, machine learning, topic modeling, and sentiment analysis were used to analyze Twitter data.                                                        | Aggressor oriented discourse is more polarized and supports vigilantism, whereas victim-oriented discourse condemns it.                                                                                     | Social media platforms should use AI to detect and reduce polarization in discussion framed around aggressors.                                                                                               |
| Moin et al. (2025)       | Bright AI for individuals   | Examined how AI affected psychological contracts, trust, and commitment in the workplace.                                               | Analysis was based on a time-lagged survey of 180 employees in Chinese firms.                                                                                        | The fulfilment of psychological contracts boosts trust and commitment. The use of AI weakens this relationship.                                                                                             | It is important to maintain fairness and transparency to maintain trust during adoption of AI.                                                                                                               |
| Shahi et al. (2025)      | Bright AI for society       | Discovered agenda formation and voting tendency prediction during 2019 European parliament election in Germany.                         | A mixed method approach combined manual annotation of tweets with machine learning-based analysis.                                                                   | A combination of social, network, and textual features enhanced the accuracy of voting-tendency prediction during the election.                                                                             | Social media variables are strategically important for political campaigns and real-time election results forecasting.                                                                                       |
| Vasist & Krishnan (2025) | Bright AI for society       | Explored how a nation's AI capability contributed to achieving sustainability targets laid out in the UN Sustainable Development Goals. | Utilized a cross-country configurational analysis using fuzzy set qualitative comparative analysis and necessary condition analysis.                                 | Infrastructure and operating environment are the most critical necessary conditions for a country's progress on the UN Sustainable Development Goals. AI talent and commercial ventures play a lesser role. | Policymakers should prioritize robust infrastructure and regulatory frameworks for harnessing AI's potential for achieving sustainability rather than narrowly focusing on AI talent or commercial ventures. |



curbing such harms. Equally important is the exploration of global governance mechanisms: What institutional, legal, or cultural frameworks enable or hinder coordinated AI oversight across borders? In alignment with the UN Sustainable Development Goals, future studies can also analyze how national AI capacities, across infrastructure, regulation, and talent, interact to shape progress toward sustainability. These directions are essential to building a more trustworthy and sustainable digital ecosystem shaped by responsible AI design and governance.

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